

### 3.2.3 2C Hinduism

Students are required to study those aspects of the religious beliefs, teachings, values and practices of Hinduism specified below and the different ways in which these are expressed in the lives of individuals, communities and societies.

They should develop a knowledge and critical understanding of:

- the specified material
- how the texts specified for study are interpreted and applied
- the influence of beliefs and teachings on individuals, communities and societies
- the causes, meanings and significance of similarities and differences in religious thought belief and practice within Hinduism
- approaches to the study of religion and belief.

They should be able to analyse and evaluate issues arising from the topics studied, and the views and arguments of the scholars prescribed for study.

Questions may be set that span more than one topic.

Students may study any version of the specified texts, but should be aware of issues related to translation where relevant. Quotations will not be used in questions.

Students should be able to use specialist language and terminology appropriately.

Exam questions will show a translation for any non-English terms (except for names of people, texts and schools of thought). However students are expected to recognise and understand the following technical terms: Trimurti, avatar, karma, ahimsa, darshan.

### Sources of wisdom and authority

- The Vedas: concept of shruti (that which is heard); the nature and authority of the Vedas, their use in worship and their importance; the distinctive nature of the Upanishads and their importance for Hindu thought; the significance of the teaching in the Purusha Sukta of the Rig Veda about the origin of the caste system.
- The smṛti texts: the status of the smṛti (remembered) texts; the importance of the following: the Ramayana; the Bhagavad Gita and the Manusmṛti.
- Gurus: the role and authority of gurus in the modern world with reference to Swami Sivananda.

### Ultimate reality

- Differing ideas about God and gods in the Rig Veda, and their importance for Hinduism today.
- The Trimurti: the nature and roles of the three elements of the Trimurti and their relationship with Brahman; the concept of avatar with particular reference to Krishna and Rama; the importance of the Trimurti and avatars in Hinduism.
- Nirguna and Saguna Brahman: Nirguna Brahman as nothingness, without qualities, beyond description and understanding; Saguna Brahman with qualities and as a personal God; the importance of both concepts for Hindus, Kena Upanishad 1:3–8.

### Self, death and afterlife

- The meaning and purpose of life: the four aims of life; and their relative importance; different understandings of the nature of moksha.
- Atman: the concept of atman and its relationship with the body and with Brahman, with reference to the views of Advaita Vedanta (non-dualism) and Samkhya (dualism) the parable of the chariot: Katha Upanishad 3.
- Samsara: the concept of samsara; beliefs about reincarnation and the causes of reincarnation with reference to the different types of karma; the realms of reincarnation and the interconnectedness of all life.

### Good conduct and key moral principles

- Good conduct: the importance of good moral conduct in Hinduism with reference to karma and karma yoga (selfless effort).
- Dharma: the concepts of Sanatana dharma (universal dharma), Varnashrama dharma (dharma for class and stage of life) and the relationship between them; the importance of each for the Hindu way of life.
- Ahimsa: the virtue of ahimsa, its application to issues concerning the embryo and the unborn child, treatment of animals and war including the use of weapons of mass destruction; different Hindu views on these issues including Gandhi's views on non-violence.

## Expressions of religious identity

- Yoga: the different paths of Yoga, their suitability for different types of character and the links between them.
- Bhakti Yoga: the nature and importance of bhakti yoga; darshan at shrines, temples and on pilgrimage with particular reference to the Ganges; the key aspects of puja.
- The changing role of ashrams: ashrams (spiritual retreat centres) in Hinduism; their role prior to the 20th century and the variety of types of ashram today, with particular reference to the Sivananda Yoga Vedanta Dhanwantari Ashram in Kerala, and Skanda Vale Ashram UK.